

Topic 6.3 - The ways teachers actually develop

A real classroom situation

A head teacher has a small budget and one question: what is the best way to help her twelve teachers get better?

She can send two of them to a conference in Karachi. She can bring a trainer in for one day for all twelve. She can buy data for an online platform. She can protect one hour a fortnight in which her teachers talk to each other about teaching. Or she can do nothing formal and require each teacher to keep a journal.

The honest answer is that these options are not ranked, they are suited to different things, and the cheapest of them is probably the most powerful. This topic is the comparison she needs.

Explanation

The figure above is the summary. The sections below give the reasoning, and each route is judged against the six principles from Topic 6.1: sustained, embedded, focused, collaborative, feedback-supported and chosen.

Conferences

A conference gathers a large number of practitioners for presentations, usually over one to three days, usually away from the school.

What it suits. Exposure to what exists beyond your own school, contact with practice you would not otherwise meet, and the discovery that a problem you

thought was yours is general. For an isolated teacher in a rural school, that last effect is not trivial.

What it cannot do. Change your practice on its own. A conference satisfies almost none of the six principles: not sustained, not embedded, rarely focused on your pupils, and the collaboration is with people you will never see again.

Cost and reach. The most expensive per teacher of all five routes and reaches the fewest. The head's two teachers in Karachi will cost more than a day's trainer for all twelve.

The defensible use is as a source of ideas that something else then develops, never as the development itself.

Workshops

A workshop is a shorter, more practical session, usually delivered to a group, often in or near the school.

What it suits. Transmitting a specific technique or a curriculum change to many teachers at once. If a new assessment format arrives, a workshop is the right instrument.

What it cannot do. Produce the practice. A workshop can put a technique in your hands and cannot make it survive contact with your Class 8 on Tuesday. Mr Naeem's eleven certificates in Topic 6.1 are eleven workshops that stopped at the first level.

Making one work. This is the practical part, because workshops are what you will actually be sent to. Three things convert a workshop from an event into development, and all three are within a participant's control: decide before you leave which single thing you will try; agree with one colleague who attended that you will each try it and compare in a fortnight; and decide what you will look at to know whether it worked. Those three supply sustained, collaborative and feedback-supported, the principles the workshop format lacks.

Online professional development platforms

Online platforms deliver courses, video and materials at a distance, and have expanded rapidly.

What it suits. Reach and cost. A platform reaches teachers a trainer cannot, at low marginal cost, on the teacher's own schedule, which matters when the alternative is travel a teacher cannot afford.

What the evidence says, carefully. Hennessy and colleagues (2022) reviewed technology use for teacher professional development in low- and middle-income countries. Note that scope: this is the right literature for this sub-topic, unlike a general claim about online learning. What they report is that development opportunities in such countries are limited, often unsustained and frequently not informed by research evidence, that technology has real potential to extend both formal programmes and informal peer learning, and that outcomes so far are **mixed**.

Mixed deserves emphasis rather than hiding. The potential is real and the delivery so far has not reliably realised it, which is the same verdict Unit 5 reached about classroom technology.

What it cannot do. Observe you. No platform sees your practice, which means it cannot supply the feedback principle, and completion rates for self-directed online courses are notoriously low without an external structure.

In Pakistani conditions add the obvious: data cost, device access and electricity are real constraints, and a platform that assumes reliable connectivity is not available to many of the teachers who most need development.

Professional learning communities

A professional learning community is a group of teachers in the same school who meet regularly to examine their own practice and their pupils' learning, with a shared focus and an expectation that what is discussed is acted on.

This is the route the head should probably choose, and the argument is that it satisfies more of the six principles than any other: it is sustained by construction, embedded in the school, focused on the pupils actually present, collaborative by definition, and capable of supplying feedback on real practice.

What it costs. Almost nothing in money and a great deal in protected time, which is the scarcest resource in a school and the reason such groups are rare. One hour a fortnight, defended against everything that will try to take it, is the whole requirement.

What defeats it. Three predictable things. It becomes an administrative meeting about timetables. It becomes a complaint session, which is a real relief and is not development. Or it avoids the specific, because discussing what happened in your classroom on Tuesday means admitting what did not work, and Unit 4's point about honesty requiring safety from consequence applies exactly.

What makes it work. A specific question rather than a general topic, evidence brought from real classrooms, and a norm that saying "this did not work" is the most valuable contribution anyone can make.

Reflective practice and self-evaluation tools

Reflective practice is the disciplined examination of your own teaching against evidence. Brookfield (2017) treats it as a professional method rather than a disposition: the point is to see your practice through more than your own eyes, including your pupils' experience of it and a colleague's view of it.

The misconception to defeat: **reflective practice means keeping a diary.** A diary of feelings records that Tuesday was difficult. Reflection establishes what happened, against evidence, and what to do differently.

Four tools, each with a different strength.

Journals. Cheapest and most under-used. The discipline that makes a journal work is the one from Unit 3: three structured sentences about a specific decision, not a general account of the day.

Portfolios. A collected body of evidence about your practice over time: plans, pupil work, observations, your own notes. Its strength is that it makes change over months visible, which no single observation can. Its weakness is that it becomes a compliance exercise the moment it is collected for appraisal, which Unit 4 explained.

Peer feedback. A colleague watches you teach and tells you something true. The most valuable and most avoided of the four. Its difficulty is not technical: it requires a relationship in which an honest observation will not be heard as an attack, and it requires that the observer is not also writing your appraisal.

Lesson study. A group plans one lesson together; one member teaches it while the others observe **the pupils rather than the teacher**; the group examines what pupils actually did and understood; the lesson is revised and taught again. The figure above gives the cycle.

Lesson study is the most demanding of the four and is worth describing carefully, because the detail that makes it work is counter-intuitive. Observers watch the pupils. That single rule removes the defensiveness that makes ordinary observation hard, because nobody is being judged, and it directs attention to what a teacher cannot see while teaching.

Activity: Spend the head's budget

Work in groups of four. You are advising the head teacher from the top of this topic. She has twelve teachers, a small budget, and the five options.

Produce a recommendation. It must name what she should do, say what she gives up, and specify how she protects it from the three things that defeat a professional learning community.

Then present to another group, whose job is to argue for a different option as strongly as they can. Allow 30 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name the five development routes and, for each, one thing it cannot do.
(*Remember*)
2. Explain why a conference is the most expensive route per teacher and what it is nonetheless good for. (*Understand*)

3. Give the three things a participant can do to convert a workshop into development, and say which principle each supplies. (*Apply*)
4. State what the review of technology for teacher development in low- and middle-income countries reports, and what that literature does not cover. (*Understand*)
5. Name the three things that defeat a professional learning community. (*Remember*)
6. In lesson study, observers watch the pupils rather than the teacher. Explain what that rule achieves. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Five routes, suited to different things and not ranked. A conference buys exposure and contact at the highest cost per teacher and satisfies almost none of the six principles. A workshop transmits a specific technique to many at once and cannot produce the practice, though a participant can supply the missing principles by deciding in advance what to try, agreeing with a colleague, and deciding what evidence would show it worked.

Online platforms buy reach and low marginal cost, and the review evidence for low- and middle-income countries reports real potential with mixed outcomes so far. No platform observes your practice, and data, devices and electricity are genuine constraints.

A professional learning community satisfies more of the principles than any other route and costs almost nothing but protected time. It is defeated by becoming an administrative meeting, by becoming a complaint session, or by avoiding the specific.

Reflective practice is disciplined examination against evidence, not a diary. Journals are cheapest, portfolios make change over time visible, peer feedback is the most valuable and most avoided, and lesson study is the most demanding, with observers watching pupils rather than the teacher.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can compare the five routes on cost, reach and what each cannot do.
- ☐ I can convert a workshop I am sent to into something that changes my practice.
- ☐ I can state what the technology evidence covers and what it does not.
- ☐ I can name what defeats a professional learning community and how to protect one.
- ☐ I can explain the lesson study cycle and why observers watch the pupils.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask whether teachers in your practicum school ever watch each other teach.

If they do, ask what happens afterwards. If they do not, ask why not, and listen for whether the reason is time, timetable, or something about how an observation would be received.

Write half a page on what you learn. The answer to "why not" is usually the third reason, and it is the one this topic says matters most.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

The head has twelve teachers and a small budget. Recommend what she should do.

Compare at least three routes against cost, reach and the six principles, make a recommendation, and state what is given up. Then set out specifically how the arrangement is protected from whatever ordinarily destroys it. Address the objection that protected time is not something a head in an understaffed government school can actually defend.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Comparison (Apply)	Three or more routes judged on cost, reach and principles rather than on preference
Recommendation with cost	Names what is given up, not only what is chosen
Protection of the arrangement (Create)	Specifies concretely how the choice is defended against the named failure modes
Answering the constraint (Evaluate)	Engages with whether protected time is actually defensible in an understaffed school, rather than assuming it

Further reading

- Villegas-Reimers, E. (2003). *Teacher professional development: An international review of the literature*. UNESCO IIEP.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000133010>
- Hennessy, S., D'Angelo, S., McIntyre, N., Koomar, S., Kreimeia, A., Cao, L., Brugha, M., & Zubairi, A. (2022). Technology use for teacher professional development in low- and middle-income countries: A systematic review. *Computers and Education Open*, 3, 100080.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.caeo.2022.100080>
- Brookfield, S. D. (2017). *Becoming a critically reflective teacher* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.

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